

Poverty in Premodern Law: Hospitals, Statutes and the Poor (Italy, c. 1560–1750), Course: Law and Humanities (prof. Sara Menzinger). University of Roma Tre - 10 November 2025, Rome, Italy.

This lecture explores what legal sources can reveal about how past societies understood and addressed poverty. Building on Brian Tierney’s pioneering work, *Medieval Poor Law: A Sketch of Canonical Theory and Its Application in England* (Berkeley and Los Angeles, 1959), it highlights the often-underused potential of legal history in the study of poverty. Particular attention is given to the so-called “hospitals of the poor”, their multiple functions, as well as to the ways in which early-modern Italian rulers transformed them into central institutions of civic and economic governance.